

RESOURCE APPLICATION INFO SESSION

Innovation Depot | April 7, 2026

Presented by Ellie Bahrmassel, Further Faster Ventures

WHAT WE'RE COVERING

20-minute overview + 25-minute Q&A

01 What you told us

04 The four resources

02 Where we're going

05 The application + evaluation

03 Why this process exists

06 How to build a strong application

WHAT YOU TOLD US

62

Survey Responses

67

Interviews

9

Incubators Analyzed

TWO FINDINGS THAT SHAPED EVERYTHING THAT FOLLOWS

Honest feedback was rare. The ecosystem had a cheerleading problem.

Support felt disconnected from where companies actually were.

That's the problem this process is designed to solve.

NORTH STAR

The Southeast's premier catalyst for ambitious founders.

*Not a coworking space. Not a networking club.
A place where serious companies get built.*

THE SHIFT

PILLAR 1

High-Performance, Metrics-Driven Culture

Resources follow demonstrated momentum.

Honest feedback. High standards.
The ecosystem you asked for.

PILLAR 2

Diverse Capital Stack Cultivation

Capital for Birmingham founders to scale without leaving to find it.

Local capital + external VCs + paid pilots.

WHY THIS PROCESS EXISTS

Strategy becomes tangible for your company.

Not a competition. Not a gate. A matching process.

Worth doing regardless of what you receive.

You're building this ecosystem as much as we are.

THE FOUR RESOURCES

The Network

Targeted expertise matched to your specific problem. Not general mentorship.

Special Projects Grant

One-time, non-dilutive. A defined initiative. Direct vendor payment.

Capital Readiness Program

Structured prep for your next raise, built around your specific stage and gaps.

Pilot Program Fund

Support to scope, propose, and close a paid pilot with a target client.

THE NETWORK

The right expert. For the right problem. Right now.

- Vetted operators, domain specialists, and advisors matched to your specific challenge — not a directory you browse, but a match we make
- Designed for targeted expertise, not general mentorship or ongoing coaching
- Most valuable when you have a specific, defined problem and need access to someone who has solved it before
- The match is based on your application and your follow-on conversation

BEST FOR

You know exactly what you need help with and need access to someone who has solved that specific problem before.

SPECIAL PROJECTS GRANT

A defined initiative. A measurable result. Non-dilutive.

- One-time, non-dilutive resource allocated to a specific, defined initiative
- Innovation Depot pays the vendor or provider directly — no cash disbursement to your company
- Examples: brand build, product sprint, key consulting hire, go-to-market investment
- Requires a well-defined initiative, a specific vendor in mind, and a measurable result you can commit to in advance

BEST FOR

You have a well-defined initiative, a specific vendor in mind, and a measurable result you can commit to in advance.

CAPITAL READINESS PROGRAM

Built around your stage, your gaps, your next round.

- Structured support to prepare for your next fundraising
- Built around your specific stage, goals, and gaps — not a one-size-fits-all program
- Covers pitch narrative, investor targeting, materials, and diligence prep
- Scope is defined in your follow-on meeting based on where you are and what you actually need

BEST FOR

You are 3–12 months from your next raise and want dedicated support to get there with confidence.

PILOT PROGRAM FUND

From conversation to signed pilot. We help you get there.

- Support to scope, propose, and launch a paid pilot with a target client or partner
- Includes resources for the commercial process — not just delivery
- Designed for founders with a specific, identified opportunity who need support closing it
- Goal: a clear, defined path from pilot to commercial relationship

BEST FOR

You have a specific target customer, a product ready for a pilot, and a clear path to converting that pilot into a commercial relationship.

THE APPLICATION

IT'S LIVE NOW

Rolling basis — open now

Five sections:
Company Foundations,
Business & Market,
Team & Founder,
Product & Brand,
and a Support Request

TIMELINE

Submit this month

Evaluation meetings:
late April – early May

Earlier submissions get
more scheduling flexibility

THE EVALUATION

Trained panel of judges

Consistent criteria applied
across all applicants

THE 9 EVALUATION DIMENSIONS

These are the areas we assess. Knowing them is your roadmap.

01

**Cap Table &
Funding Strategy**

02

Team

03

**Customer &
Problem Validation**

04

Market

05

**Competitive
Landscape**

06

Product & Brand

07

**Business Model
& Operations**

08

Unit Economics

09

**Founder Ambition
& Trajectory**

THE FOLLOW-ON MEETING

Every applicant has one. No exceptions.

This is not a reward for a strong application. Completing the application guarantees everyone a meeting.

Not a verdict. A structured conversation.

Where you are, where you're going, what we found, what resources fit.

Come prepared. Engage honestly.

Know your numbers. Know your narrative. The more you bring, the more you leave with.

HOW TO BUILD A STRONG APPLICATION

- 01 Be specific, not aspirational.** Evidence over conviction.
- 02 Lead with your strengths.** Surface the signal. Don't make evaluators find it.
- 03 Name your gaps.** Coachability is a scored dimension. Founders who acknowledge gaps score higher.
- 04 Nail 'why this, why now.'** What problem, what you've tried, what success looks like in 90 days.
- 05 Apply now.** Earlier = more flexibility. Don't wait to feel ready.

ONE THING TO CARRY OUT OF THIS ROOM

This process is designed to move your company forward, not evaluate it.

The more honestly you engage, the more you get out of it.

APPLY TODAY